Credo, who told me she was writing a letter to Bob, asking for a divorce.

I looked at her in horror. "Because of anything J said about him?"

"No, no," she replied. "I've been thinking of it for a long time."

6

I felt pretty good about my corporalcy. It meant a little more money, of course, but what was really important was that I was promoted. My incapacity to gain promotions, exhibited so forcefully at the Navy Yard, made my promotion a matter of distinction. I wrote to Gertrude about it and made sure that on the return address I wrote Corporal Isaac Asimov, with the first word underlined.

Then, the next day, July 12, my first full day as corporal, I was sent

down to the post office to run an errand. I had been there before and had dealt with a young woman who had seemed both efficient and intelligent.

This time she was not at the desk but some male soldier was. He was talking to someone and paying no attention to me. I stood there, growing visibly more impatient, and when he turned to me at last I told him what I wanted in rather peremptory fashion.

"Can't be done," he said, lazily.

"Oh yeah?" I said. "Well, how about letting me speak to the WAC over there?"

He turned to call her and, for the first time, I noticed he wore a captain's bars. Such was my surprise at encountering an officer where I had thought I was speaking to a fellow corporal that I did precisely the wrong thing. I snapped to attention, saluted, and said, "Beg your pardon, sir."

It was virtual suicide. The captain who, until then, had treated me as a human being, if a totally unimportant one, now turned upon me with a snarl. I had shown fear and, as any other dog would have done, he raised his hackles and the corners of his lips at the scent of it.

"How long have you had those stripes, Corporal?"

"I sewed them on yesterday, sir."